that “the problems may well break our economy.”[135] In July, he publicly admitted the Indian need for more aid, particularly from the US.[136]

He was in luck. By late 1957 and especially spring 1958, as Merrill notes, aiding India in its competition with China had become a “cause célèbre” and “somewhat of an ideological crusade” in the US. In this case, “strategic interests coincided with ideals.” Newspapers and magazines joined earlier advocates of India to stress the importance of an Indian victory in “the race.” A resolution proposed by Senator John F. Kennedy (D-MA) and Senator John Sherman Cooper (R-KY)—and attached to the Senate version of the 1958 foreign assistance bill—had identified India as deserving of special attention. Kennedy spoke in the Senate of the “choice in Asia,” emphasizing that “India, like the United States, is engaged in a struggle of coexistence—in its case with China.” And Cooper asked if the US was going “to be so blind as to repeat our mistake” of losing another Asian giant by not doing enough.[137]

The administration, however, decided that while congressional reaction had seemed “fairly satisfactory,” it did not want to push its luck with special legislation that B. K. Nehru had been seeking. It instead decided to follow World Bank president Eugene Black’s suggestion of a “creditors’ meeting.”[138] The US took the lead in August 1958 to form what became the India Aid Consortium with Canada, Japan, West Germany, and the UK. Working through the Bank, it announced pledges of $350 million for India immediately and envisioned commitments of $600 million through the rest of the five-year plan. This development took place in the context of a change in the administration’s broader approach—in an unusual move, the administration requested less money for military assistance than economic assistance for FY1959. The administration also decided on more PL-480 agreements for India that June and September and, working with the Bank that July, rescheduled some debt repayments.[139]

That fall, the India cause in the US continued to be driven by a mix of hope and fear. Intelligence analysts believed that India could succeed—with a little help from its friends. They emphasized the importance of aid in stopping and reversing what they believed was a worrying trend: “a weakening of the Congress Party and toward an increase in Communist strength.” This was especially critical because Washington needed to start considering the prospect of a post-Nehru India.[140]